

TABLE 6

**Ineffective Treatments for Cold Symptoms in Children**

| Treatment                       | Study type                                                                                           | Findings                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Antibiotics                     | 2 Cochrane reviews of 11 RCTs <sup>46,47</sup>                                                       | No benefit for symptom duration or severity compared with no antibiotics or placebo                                                                                                                       |
| Antihistamine monotherapy       | Cochrane review of 3 RCTs <sup>6</sup>                                                               | No more effective than placebo for cough                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Antihistamine plus decongestant | Cochrane review of 2 RCTs <sup>6</sup>                                                               | No more effective than placebo for cough                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Antitussives                    | Cochrane review of 3 RCTs <sup>6</sup>                                                               | No more effective than placebo for cough                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Antitussive plus bronchodilator | Cochrane review of RCTs <sup>6</sup>                                                                 | No more effective than placebo for cough                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Echinacea                       | Cochrane review of RCTs <sup>49</sup>                                                                | No benefit for symptom severity, peak symptom severity, number of days of fever, or parental report of severity compared with placebo                                                                     |
| Intranasal corticosteroids      | Cochrane review of 2 studies <sup>69</sup>                                                           | No decrease in episodes requiring oral corticosteroids, emergency department visits, hospital admissions, frequency of wheezing, or duration of episodes                                                  |
| Oral prednisolone               | RCT of a 5-day course <sup>69</sup>                                                                  | No significant difference in duration of hospitalization, time from admission to discharge, mean 7-day symptom score reported by parent, or readmission for wheezing within 1 month compared with placebo |
| Steam                           | RCT of adults and children with subgroup analysis of 200 children 3 to 16 years of age <sup>31</sup> | No improvement in symptom severity with inhalation of steam for 5 minutes 3 times daily                                                                                                                   |
| Vitamin D                       | RCT of 703 children 1 to 5 years of age <sup>18</sup>                                                | 2,000 IU of vitamin D did not reduce overall respiratory infections compared with 400 IU when taken daily for a minimum of 4 months                                                                       |

RCT = randomized controlled trial.

Information from references 6, 18, 31, 46, 47, 49, and 69.